

challenges have emerged. Last month, we actually published all of our policies and documentation on our new open source-centred site ([opensource.google.com](https://opensource.google.com)). These docs are based on all the lessons we have learned from working with open source at a large technology company for many years. We know that the way we do things may not be right for everyone else, but we published these docs under an open licence so others can adapt them to whatever makes sense at their company.

**Q Is it the commercialised open source or FOSS (free and open source software) that gets more interest from Google?**

Many successful free and open source projects have corporate sponsorship in varying forms, even if that simply means that they have employees whose full-time jobs are to work on the project. This is probably the biggest way that Google supports many open source projects. For instance, we do give money to the foundations behind Linux, LLVM, Git and Samba. But, more importantly, we employ engineers whose sole job is to contribute to and help maintain those projects because they're very important to us.

**Q What do you think are the major challenges in releasing an open source solution nowadays?**

Once you get past whatever technical problem a given project is trying to address, one of the biggest challenges almost inevitably ends up being community management. But this is

not unique to open source; it is also true inside any engineering organisation. People are complicated and messy. They can have very strong opinions, they often do not care about the same things you care about, and they have lives outside of your project that will at some point bleed into their work in unexpected and inexplicable ways.

Managing people, whether that means a formal employee relationship or just as a part of an open source community, is incredibly hard. But it can be so incredibly rewarding.

I believe helping facilitate a group of diverse people with a common goal and working together to build something is greater than the sum of their individual contributions. That is at least why I love what I do.

**“**  
*We have never had a 'one size fits all' approach to open source.*  
**”**

**Q How does Google resolve those challenges?**

That is really the key question! It starts with trying to create an environment where people feel welcome to participate, and where they really can contribute on an equal footing. It also means being honest about the fact that conflict will arise and being prepared to handle it when it does. All this means fostering an environment where grace can be extended

when people mess up, but also not be afraid to pull out the weeds when they are choking out the flowers.

We know we do not always hit that mark, but that is what I aim for.

**Q In addition to your current role at Google, you are apparently a huge supporter of WordPress. What do you feel makes WordPress a platform that has democratised publishing?**

Particularly as WordPress is self-hosted on a personal domain name, anyone can download the software, load it up on their server or any hosting platform and publish on the Internet without having to ask anyone for permission. There are no use policies that need to be 'accepted' specifying what you can and cannot post, and there are no terms and conditions to agree to. Today, countless platforms are enabling you to do this, but that was not as true 10 to 15 years ago.

**Q What do you think are the major common factors between Google and WordPress?**

Both believe, at the most fundamental level, that the Internet must be an open platform for innovation.

**Q Finally, how do you see the future of open source, moving beyond Google and WordPress?**

There is far more open source code yet to be written than everything that exists today. So really, we are still only at the beginning of the open source growth curve. We all have to look forward to it. **END** 

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